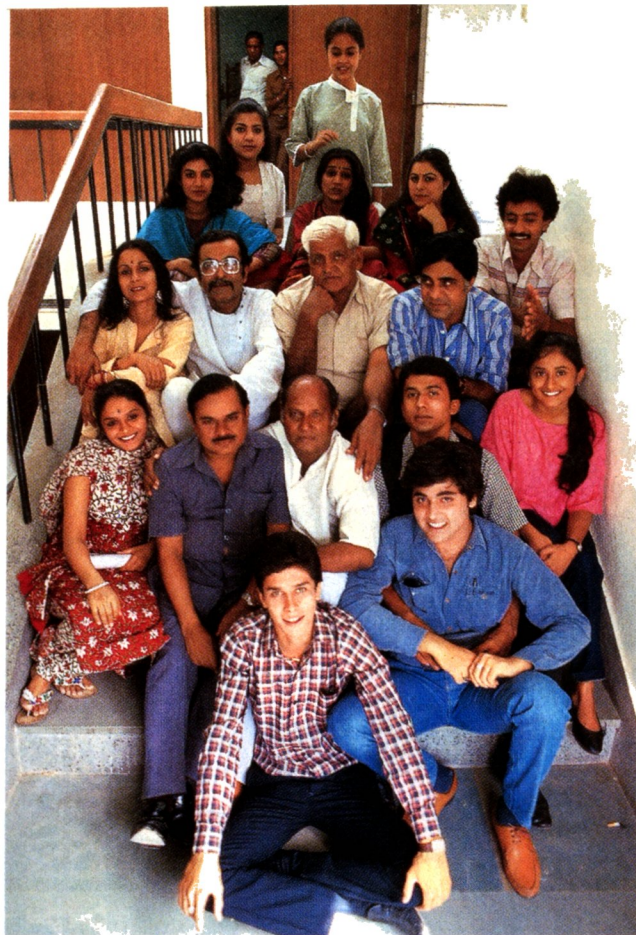


|1984| FIRST INDIAN SOAP

The Small Screen Wonder

A soap with people like us had the country hooked, revolutionising prime time TV

It was a year that modern Indian history will find difficult to forget, a year of violence, of Indira Gandhi's assassination, storming of the Golden Temple and the Bhopal gas tragedy. But it was also a year that redefined television history. A quiet soap, first labelled a double bore, humdrum even, entered homes all over the country, enamouring people with the story of a family of five daughters and two sons. But this people-like-us tale set off a revolution that has crossed generations. Its popularity introduced people to prime time television. The simple tale of a family, its aspirations, ups and downs couched in a social message was the brainchild of the then-secretary of I&B Ministry, S.S. Gill, who drew inspiration from a Mexican soap opera. It drew in the elite and masses alike. "The cast and I were walking down Palika Bazaar and people started chasing us. That's when it struck. People were actually watching us." By the time the soap ran its course in December 1985, 157 episodes were telecast, 214 crore viewer-hours were spent watching the soap, 40 million viewers switched on their television sets twice a week and Doordarshan received 400 letters a day related to the serial that commanded an average of 75 to 85 per cent rating in north India. Down south in Chennai, a city where Hindi programmes were traditionally unsuccessful, the rating was at 50 per cent. Penned by Manohar Shyam Joshi, *Hum Log* had become a phenomenon and an obsession. "Joshi had a knack of picking up each actor's personal talent and incorporating it into that of the character. It was almost like you were living your own life," says Chaturvedi. The *Hum Log* platform had also proved to be a launch pad for brands like Maggi and Colgate-Palmolive. It's now used as a marketing case study, a virtual programming revolution, making prime time a popular word among producers. Chaturvedi believes its popularity lay in the content, in Joshi's vision of characters that exist in every single family and in his linguistic acumen. It remains to date one of the few serials that have managed to successfully tap into the ever-elusive TRP ratings. From virtually no takers in 1984 to an average of 15 software companies contending for the prime time spot the following year, *Hum Log* drove home the value of television as the best and quickest medium to communicate. "Which serial has had the power to do that for close to two years?" Chaturvedi, now a sports commentator and anchor, asks. And then adds, "For one entire generation, I still remain Nanhe."



THE CAST AND CREW
OF HUM LOG

THE MAIN EVENT

Operation Bluestar

For the first time in 400 years the recital of gurbani was about to stop in the Golden Temple. As dusk fell on June 5, commandos dressed in jet-black dungarees slipped into the temple complex through the road between the serais and the Guru Ramdass langar building. They were able to bring back safely Akali Dal leaders like Harchand Singh Tohra along with their key aides living in the Teja Singh Samundari Hall, Guru Ramdass Serai and Guru Nanak Niwas. The darkened sky was lit with bright red tracers and massive columns of smoke billowed from the langar building where heavy fighting took place.

India Today, June 30, 1984

ALSO

- Poisonous gas escapes from a Union Carbide plant in Bhopal, killing thousands
- Prime Minister Indira Gandhi is assassinated
- Her death triggers anti-Sikh riots, thousands die

Cellphones and Cancer A Californian physician sued his phone company for giving him a tumour in 2002.

Trans Fat Started in the US in 2006, banning trans fat became a worldwide movement eventually.

Doomsday 2012 According to the Mayan calendar, December 2012 is said to be the end of the world.

Recession In 2008, stock markets and financial institutions all around the world collapsed.

Swine Flu Hundreds of cases were reported in Mexico in 2009. Nations reviewed their health care policies.